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Detecting Code of Conduct Violations in Sri Lankan News with LLMs

Sinhala & English · gpt-4.1, Gemini 3.5 Flash, SinLlama 8B · 9 ways of asking, confidence scores

The first step was turning the code into rules a model can judge from the article text alone

code_of_conduct.json: 17 rules in 5 groups, each written so it can be checked from the article itself.

Group	Rules
Accuracy	2.2.a unsourced claims · 2.2.b non-credible source · 2.2.c irrelevant source · 2.5 mixing comment and fact
Harm and sensitivity	6.1.a sensational treatment · 6.1.b murder-method detail · 6.1.c crime-method detail · 6.5 suicide-method detail
Crime identification	6.2.i naming sex-crime victims · 6.2.ii naming young accused · 6.2.iii identifying relatives of the accused
Discrimination	6.3 communal discord · 6.4.i pejorative references · 6.4.ii irrelevant identity details
Privacy	7.1 private and family life · 7.4 children · 7.5 people in hospitals and institutions

Each rule records

Obligation
what the journalist must do

Conditions
all must hold for a breach

Exceptions
public interest, consent …

Evidence cues
words that point to a breach

- **Left out:** sections 2.1, 2.3, 2.4, 3, 4, 5, 7.2, 7.3, 8, 9 (need fact-checking, photos or newsroom knowledge)
- **Two labels only:** VIOLATION / NO_VIOLATION; missing information is never evidence
- **Sinhala translation** with the same rule ids, tested later

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We built the dataset by manually annotating each article at three levels: violation or not, which rule, and which words

Every approach is graded against these hand-made answers, on the same 106 articles.

1 Violation?

Does the article break the code?

e.g. VIOLATION / NO_VIOLATION

2 Violated rule

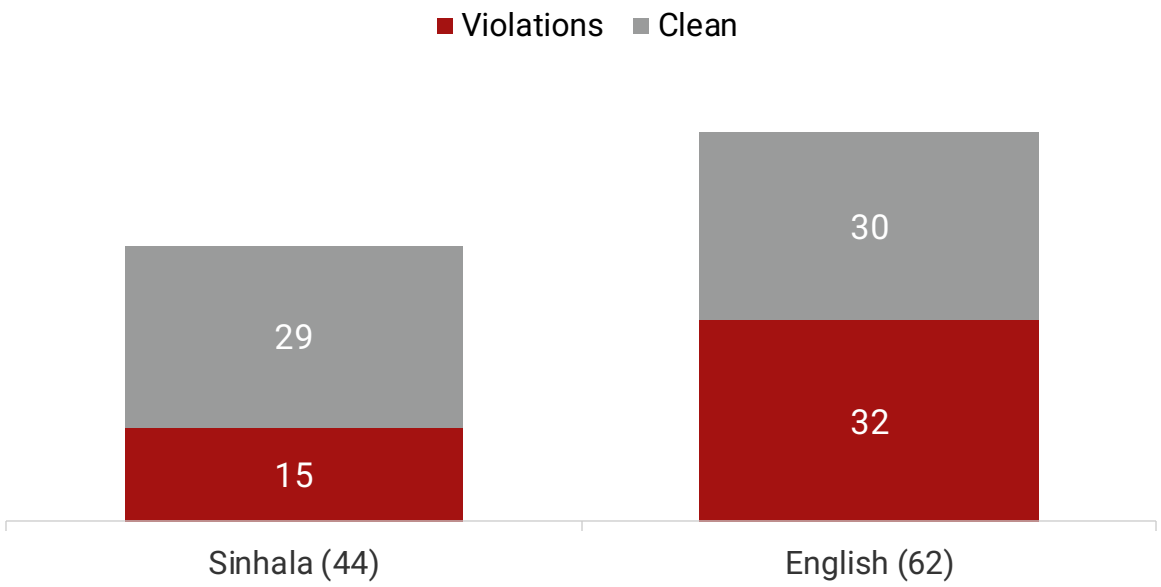
Which of the 17 rules?

e.g. 6.1.b, 2.5

3 Violated part

Which exact words break it?

e.g. the sentences describing how a murder was done → 6.1.b



The annotated dataset

47
violations
15 Sinhala · 32 English

59
clean articles
29 Sinhala · 30 English

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Each article was tested 9 ways (3 tasks × 3 prompt styles) on 3 models

The task decides how much the model must say; the prompt style decides how it is guided.

	Zero-shot code + article	**Few-shot** + 3 worked examples per language	**Per-rule** a verdict for each of the 17 rules
YES/NO says YES or NO	1	2	3
Rule detection lists rule ids, e.g. 2.2.a, 6.4.ii	4	5	6
Highlights quotes the words and names the rule	7	8	9

Counts as "violation" when: YES/NO says YES · rule detection names at least one rule · highlights finds words in the article

Every way runs 3 times (answers vary between identical runs), and scores are averaged.

3 models

gpt-4.1
OpenAI · large, general-purpose · API

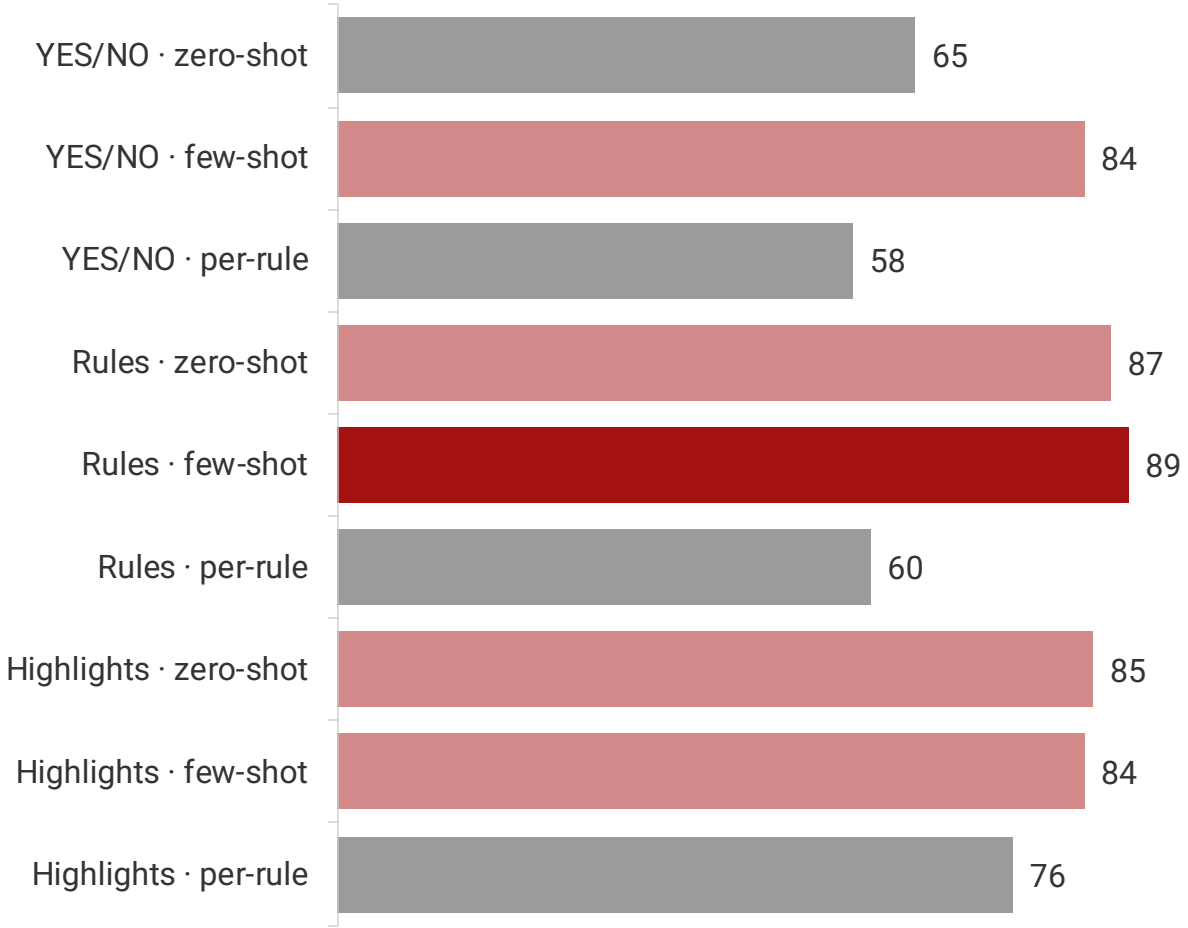
Gemini 3.5 Flash
Google · fast, cheaper · API

SinLlama 8B
Small open Sinhala model · local GPU

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In English, rule detection with few-shot examples is the best of the 9 ways, because F2 rewards catching violations

gpt-4.1 on 62 English articles (32 violations, 30 clean). F2, mean of 3 runs.



$$F_2 = \frac{5 \times \text{Precision} \times \text{Recall}}{4 \times \text{Precision} + \text{Recall}}$$

Why F2 picks the winner

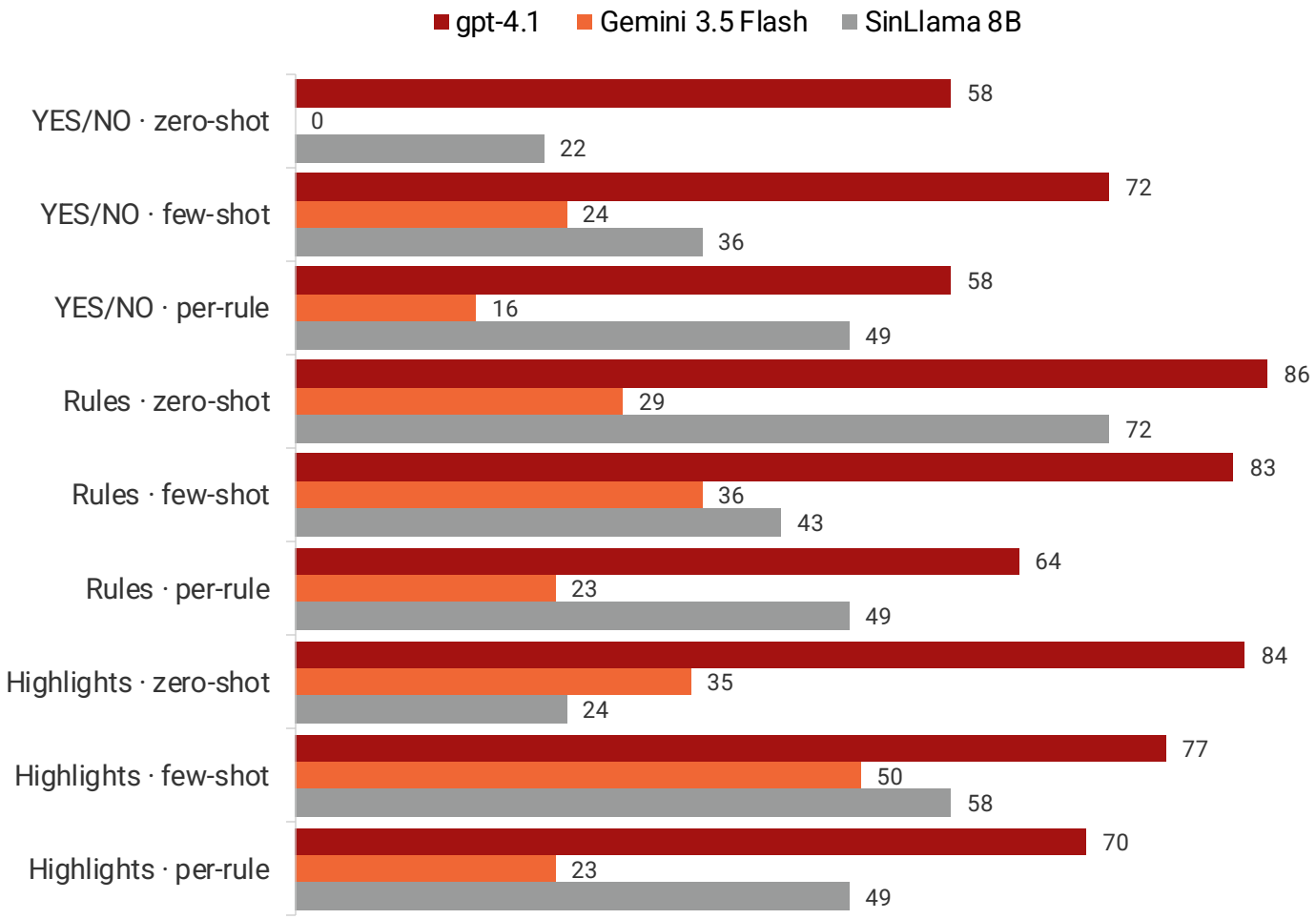
gpt-4.1, English	Rules · zero-shot	Rules · few-shot
Precision	96	90
Recall	84	89
Caught per run (of 32)	27.0	28.3
False alarms per run (of 30)	1.0	3.3
F1	90 ← F1's pick	89
F2	87	89 ← F2's pick

- **F2 trades a couple of false alarms** for one more caught violation; a reviewer dismisses a false alarm in seconds
- **YES/NO zero-shot:** 95% precision but F2 65; it misses 13 of 32 violations per run
- **Precision is 90–96 in every format,** so F2 ranks the 9 ways by violations caught

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In Sinhala, gpt-4.1 reaches F2 86 with rule detection, while the other two models stay far behind

44 Sinhala articles (15 violations, 29 clean). F2, mean of 3 runs (Gemini: 1 run).



86

gpt-4.1 best
(rule detection, zero-shot)
close to its English 89

50

Gemini 3.5 Flash best
YES/NO zero-shot = 0:
it never says YES

72 †

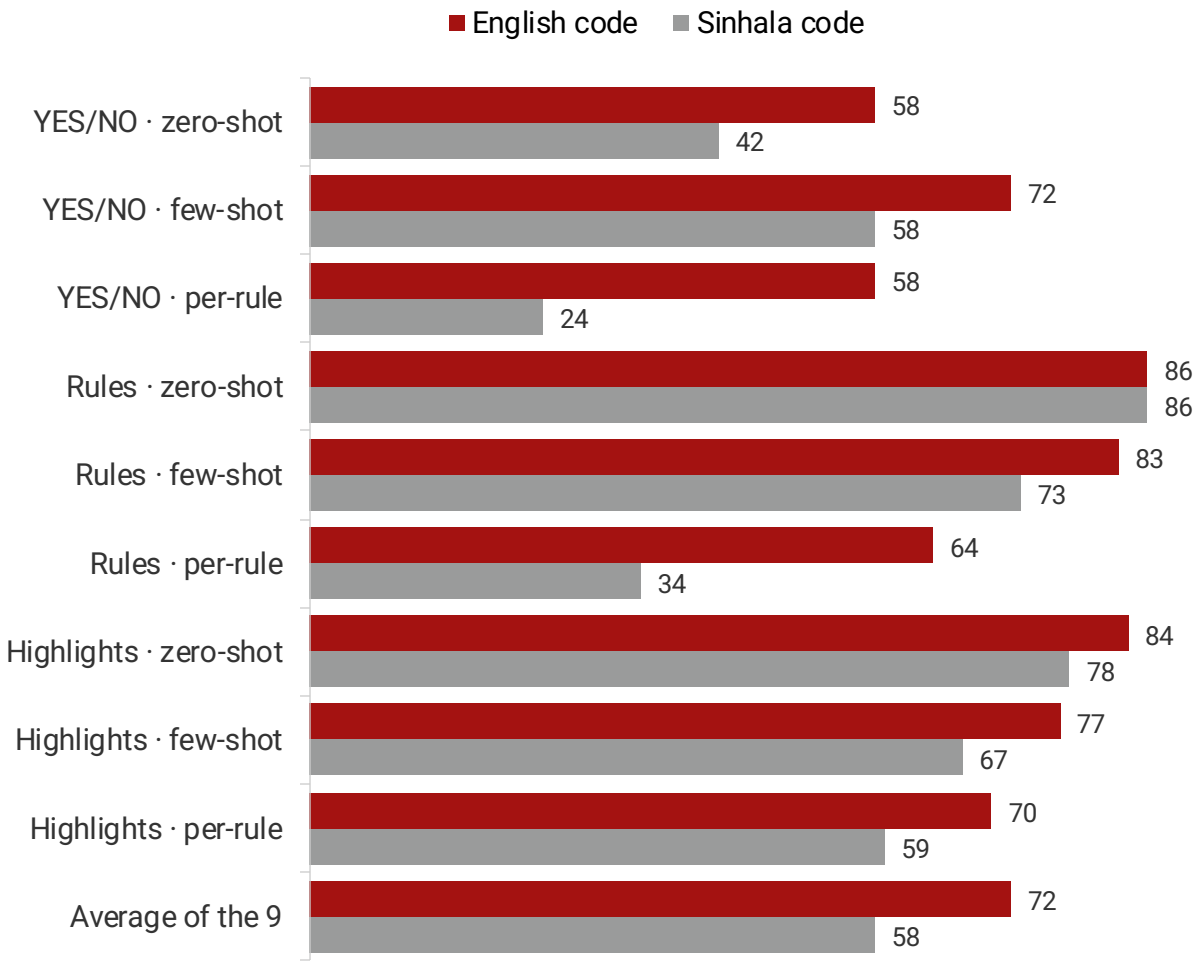
SinLlama best, only by
flagging all 44 articles

Rule detection and highlights (77–86) beat YES/NO (58–72), as in English.

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We translated the code of conduct into Sinhala, but Sinhala articles are judged better with the English code

gpt-4.1 on the 44 Sinhala articles, same prompts, only the code's language changed. F2, mean of 3 runs.



Worse in 8 of 9 formats, never better

3,419
tokens: English code

7,535
tokens: Sinhala code (2.2×)

- **Twice the tokens** for the same rules: a longer, more fragmented prompt
- **Trained mostly on English:** "public interest", "verification" are rarer and less exact in Sinhala
- **Mixed languages:** instructions and rule ids stay English, so the prompt switches language
- **Not the articles:** with the English code, best Sinhala F2 86 ≈ best English 89

Decision: keep the code in English for every article

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Next steps: more reviewed data, cheaper deployment, and a reviewer workflow built on the scores

Data

- **Review more Sinhala violations** and a set of English clean articles
- **Add Tamil:** 1,380 reviewed clean Tamil articles already exist

Models and methods

- **Probability scores** for rule detection and highlights
- **Train BERT / XLM-R** on the LLM's labels; compare with the SVM + TF-IDF baseline